

From selfies to selflessness

If an alien race were to spy on our digital communication today, humanity as a whole would come across as a very narcissistic and self-centered species. Chew on this little factoid for instance: over 70 percent of all digital data generated in the last year comprised entirely of selfies. Okay, I just made that up, but you'd be forgiven if you thought it was true, given the number of selfies you see everywhere. There are duckface selfies, velfies, melfies and what have you. There's even a selfie visualisation website called selfecity.net, which I came across while researching the data visualisation story. It aims to investigate the style of selfies in five different cities across the world. Makes you wonder what this world is coming to, right?

Thankfully, altruism and philanthropy aren't new to geeks. Geeks the world over have been donating copious amounts of time to Open Source software development for a long time. Whether it was furthering the development of a Linux distro or creating a module for a particular software on any of the many online open source forges, or even those without coding skills donating their time to clean up documentation, if nothing else – geeks have been a surprisingly conscientious lot.

Considering the bad rep technology gets these days – getting blamed for everything from clogged arteries to clogged kitchen sinks – it's worth noting...rather, worth celebrating some of the things technology is getting right.

Tech altruism, in the digital era, has taken many forms. The first and most basic is the way people from all over the world come together to support causes with the help of technology. Some may call it armchair activism or lazy charity, but at the end of the day it has an impact, no matter how minor you think the individual contribution might be. The next is individuals sharing their knowledge or time towards a common goal or for greater good. Take the example of Wikipedia – the world's largest database of knowledge – all created by individuals with a sense of giving back to the community. The fact that today it's the sixth most used website in the world speaks volumes about how important and influential it has been for the world at large.

Erissolver.com, one of the most recent examples of harnessing collective intelligence and people's inherent desire to do good, is also

a fine example. The website uses structured brainstorming techniques to solve complex problems that often don't have a single solution or are beyond the capacity of a single individual to solve. The featured problem at the time of writing this editorial was "How can we stop the river water quality of a country from deteriorating?".

Technology today isn't just about addressing the bigger issues plaguing the world, like pollution or lack of health care (being worked on by some of the brightest minds in the world, and our cover story this month chronicles all of them), it even involves trying to find solutions to the seemingly small issues like saving some of the world's endangered languages. As shocking as it may sound, languages are also dying out at an alarming rate. By some estimates, only 10% of the world's 6000+ languages might survive to the next couple of generations. To save those languages, intelligent apps are being developed that will preserve them for posterity. Native speakers of those languages themselves – folks who are often octogenarians – are learning to use technology to help in the effort.

What is clear from all of the above examples is that such initiatives can only begin and end with YOU – the individual. You are at the center of the proverbial problem and also the ultimate solution. Towards this end, Digit is launching a technology outreach program, wherein we're seeking your support and the support of manufacturers we work with to take this gift of technology (and knowledge) to those who don't have access to it. The plan is simple: if you have spare technology products lying around – be it an old laptop, PC, mobile phone or even a solitary motherboard – we'll ensure it reaches someone who desperately needs it. So come forward in whatever little way you can. Details on page 89 and more in Robert's column.

Let us all pledge to move away from selfies and take a step towards selflessness. Do your bit and earn your tech karma.



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"Considering the bad rep technology gets these days, it's worth celebrating some of the things technology is getting right"

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth Parwatay'.

Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
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